

# PLANNING A STORY

Structuring your ideas before you write



## 1 What is it?

### Planning A Story

Planning a story means **structuring your ideas before you write** — deciding on character, setting, and the shape of events so the writing itself flows more easily.

idea → structure → write

## 2 See it in action

A simple story mountain

Opening → build-up → climax → resolution — a classic shape to plan around.

Planning a character

Decide who they are, what they want, what stops them before writing a single line.

Planning an ending first

Some writers plan the final line before anything else, then build backward toward it.

A five-minute plan

Even a few bullet points — setting, character, event, ending — can transform a rushed piece into a controlled one.



### Keep going!

Before writing, jot down just **four words** — opening, build-up, climax, ending — and one phrase for each. That's often plan enough.

### FUN FACT

The "story mountain" (opening, build-up, climax, resolution) is one of the most widely taught planning structures because it's simple enough to sketch in under a minute.

### 3 Why writers use it

**Planning A Story helps writers:** avoid a story that wanders or runs out of ideas halfway through, make sure the structure (opening, build-up, climax, ending) is deliberate rather than accidental, and save time by solving structural problems before writing begins.

Under exam time pressure, even a two-minute plan — one line each for opening, build-up, twist, ending — dramatically improves how controlled and complete a piece of writing feels.

### 4 Where you'll spot it

#### Exam creative writing

Examiners can usually tell within a paragraph whether a piece was planned — a controlled shape scores far higher than a wandering one.

#### Novel writing

Many novelists plan an entire book's structure on index cards or a single page before writing a single chapter.



#### Watch out!

A plan doesn't need to be long — spending ten minutes writing a detailed plan and running out of time to finish the actual story is a common and costly mistake in timed writing.



#### Mfalme says...

Plan your **ending before your opening** — knowing where you're headed makes every sentence along the way easier to write with purpose.

### 5 Quick recap

Structures ideas before writing

Prevents a wandering, unfinished story

Even a quick plan helps enormously



#### Look here!

Try planning a story in exactly five bullet points, then writing it in ten minutes flat — notice how much more controlled it feels.